

The 1st Light

"Pilot Episode"

Written by

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PRE-PRODUCTION ANNOTATION LEGEND

^P Prop	^S Shot	^C Camera	^L Lighting
^X SFX	^V VFX	^W Wardrobe	^D Set Note

Highlighted annotations are visible in pre-production mode only. Items marked P and W preserve their text in clean mode; all others are removed.

1 EXT. COASTAL HIGHWAY -- AERIAL -- DAWN 1

WIDE AERIAL SHOT^S DRONE TRACKING, moving south along coastline^C

A winding highway hugs the cliffs above a restless ocean. Practical location: Big Sur, CA. Need permits for drone.^D A single pair of headlights cuts through the pre-dawn fog. Natural pre-dawn blue, fog diffusion.^L

CUT TO:

2 INT. SARAH'S CAR -- MOVING -- DAWN 2

CLOSE-UP^S MOUNTED DASHBOARD CAM^C

SARAH CHEN (30s, sharp eyes, tired face) grips the steering wheel of a battered 1998 Honda Civic^P. A paper coffee cup^P sits in the cupholder, long cold. She wears a wrinkled blazer over a faded band t-shirt^W -- someone who left in a hurry. Dashboard glow on face, blue-grey ambient from windows.^L

Her phone buzzes. She glances at it -- cracked iPhone^P on the passenger seat displaying "DAD -- 3 Missed Calls." She silences it without answering. Phone vibration buzz, two short pulses.^X

SARAH
(to herself, barely
audible)
Not yet.

She reaches for the coffee cup^P, takes a sip, grimaces. SLOW PUSH IN on her reflection in the rearview mirror.^C

SMASH CUT TO:

3 EXT. PINE RIDGE MOTEL -- PARKING LOT -- MORNING

3

WIDE SHOT^S

Motel exterior: run-down, 1970s architecture, neon sign partially burnt out reading "P_NE R_DGE MOT_L."^D The Civic pulls into a near-empty lot. Only two other cars: a rusted pickup truck^P and a black SUV with tinted windows^P. The SUV feels conspicuous. Harsh morning sun, long shadows from the motel sign.^L

Sarah steps out, stretches. She pulls a leather duffel bag^P from the back seat and walks toward the office. Gravel crunch underfoot. Distant highway traffic.^X Remove modern cell tower visible behind motel -- period accuracy.^V

4 INT. PINE RIDGE MOTEL -- FRONT OFFICE -- MORNING

4

STEADICAM follows Sarah through the door^C

Interior: wood paneling, hunting trophies, dusty plastic plants. A tube TV^P plays the local news with the sound off.^D A bell jingles as Sarah enters. Behind the counter sits EARL (60s, leathery skin, reading glasses perched on his nose), flipping through a fishing magazine^P. Earl: flannel shirt, suspenders, reading glasses on a chain.^W

EARL
(not looking up)
Single or double.

SARAH
Single. Something in the back, if
you have it.

EARL
(finally looking up,
studying her)
Running from something or running
to something?

SARAH
(a beat, then a tired
smile)
Ask me when I check out.

★

INSERT^S -- Earl slides a brass room key^P (not a keycard -- old school) across the counter. The tag reads Room 7^P. Metal key sliding on Formica counter.^X

CUT TO:

5 INT. MOTEL ROOM 7 -- MORNING

5

WIDE establishing, then MEDIUM on Sarah^s

Room: faded floral bedspread, wood-grain furniture, landscape painting bolted to wall. Bathroom visible through half-open door.^d Sarah drops the duffel bag^p on the bed. She crosses to the window, parts the curtains. Through the glass: the black SUV^p hasn't moved. Venetian blind shadows across Sarah's face -- film noir callback.^l SLOW DOLLY from behind Sarah toward the window, rack focus from her shoulder to the SUV outside.^c

SARAH

(under her breath)

Okay. So it's like that.

She unzips the duffel bag^p. Inside: clothes, a laptop^p, a manila envelope thick with documents^p, and at the bottom, wrapped in a cloth -- a compact handgun^p. EXTREME CLOSE-UP^s on her hand hovering over the gun. She chooses the manila envelope^p instead. Zipper opening. Rustling fabric. Paper sliding.^x

CUT TO:

5A INT. MOTEL ROOM 7 -- MOMENTS LATER

5A

Documents spread across the bed. TOP-DOWN OVERHEAD SHOT looking straight down at the documents.^c We glimpse fragments: financial spreadsheets^p, photographs of a corporate building^p, a hand-drawn map^p with red circles. Sarah arranges them methodically, building a case only she understands. Insert legible text on document close-ups in post -- hero props will be blank on set.^v

Her phone rings again. This time she answers. Phone ringtone -- generic, not personalized. She never bothered.^x

SARAH

Dad, I can't talk right now. I'm handling it.

FATHER (V.O.)

Handling it? Sarah, you took the files. Do you have any idea--

SARAH

I have every idea. That's the problem.

She hangs up. Stares at the documents. SLOW ZOOM into the photograph of the corporate building.^c Dial tone hum, then

silence.^x

FADE TO BLACK.

NOTE: END OF TEASER / COLD OPEN. Estimated runtime: 4-5 minutes. Scenes 1-5A establish Sarah's isolation, the mystery of the SUV, and the stakes (files, gun, estranged father). The motel becomes our primary location for Act One. **Location scout needed for Pine Ridge Motel exterior.**

SCENE BREAKDOWN

*The full machine-readable breakdown is in `example.breakdown`.
Below is a formatted summary.*